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(iv) Each atomic orbital has a specific direction (except s-orbital which is spherical) and hence orbital overlap takes place in the direction that maximizes overlap

Let us explain the covalent bond formation in hydrogen, fluorine and hydrogen fluoride using VB theory.

10.8 Orbital Overlap

When atoms combines to form a covalent molecule, the atomic orbitals of the combining atoms overlap to form a covalent bond. The bond pair of electrons will occupy the overlapped region of the orbitals. Depending upon the nature of overlap we can classify the covalent bonding between the two atoms as sigma (σ) and pi (π) bonds.

10.8.1 Sigma and Pi bonds

When two atomic orbitals overlap linearly along the axis, the resultant bond is called a sigma (σ) bond. This overlap is also called 'head-on overlap' or 'axial overlap'. Overlap involves an s orbital (s-s and s-p overlaps) will always result in a sigma bond as the s orbital is spherical. Overlap between two p orbitals along the molecular axis will also result in sigma bond formation. When we consider x-axis as molecular axis, the p_x-p_x overlap will result in σ-bond.

When two atomic orbitals overlaps sideways, the resultant covalent bond is called a pi (π)bond. When we consider x-axis as molecular axis, the p_y-p_y and p_z-p_z overlaps will result in the formation of a π-bond.

Following examples will be useful to understand the overlap:

10.8.2 Formation of hydrogen (H_2) Molecule

Electronic configuration of hydrogen atom is $1s^1$

During the formation of H_2 molecule, the 1s orbitals of two hydrogen atoms containing one unpaired electron with opposite spin overlap with each other along the internuclear axis. This overlap is called s-s overlap. Such axial overlap results in the formation of a σ-covalent bond.

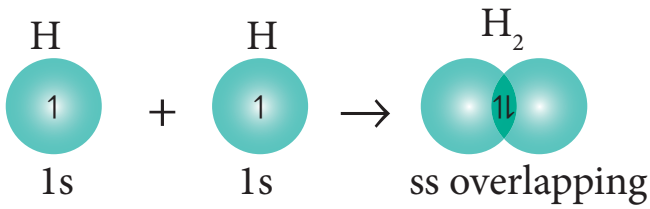


Fig 10. 18 Formation of hydrogen molecule